MINORITY REPORT

ks on Christians, and a systemic policy targeting of Muslims



DEMOLITION OF FAITH A church under construction in Subhashgram being vandalised, with rooftop crosses and doors damaged, Jul. 5

on private prayer meetings, homes, churches or other gatherings; the BCP counted eight that involved assaults, mob violence or vandalism. "We tried to speak to the honourable chief minister several times, in vain. He even gave us an appointment once, then cancelled it," Mullick says. Describing the pattern of attacks, he adds: "The culprits target houses where Sunday prayers are organised for new Christians. They snatch away the Bible or rosary and start claiming people are being forcibly converted." FIRs could be registered in only 14-15 cases, he alleges. "The police is often unwilling to help the victims and sides with the culprits."

DIFFERENT STROKES

Bengal's minority report so far suggests a difference in the approach of right-wing vigilantes to Christianity and Islam. It's direct intimidation for the former—at levels that, by October 5, had persuaded the BCP to approach the national and state human rights commissions and the National Commission for Minorities. For Muslims, apprehensions exist both at the level of physical and livelihood security as well as structural questions of representation and affirmative action.

Within days of taking office in May, the Suvendu Adhikari government discontinued religion-based welfare schemes, including monthly assistance to imams and muezzins. It also scrapped a two-tier list of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in line with a 2024 Calcutta High Court judgment that had struck down the inclusion of 77 communities, predominantly Muslim.

Both were contentious policies marked as 'Muslim appeasement' by the BJP. The latter was criticised for wholesale inclusion of Muslim caste groups without proper socio-economic considerations; now the wholesale exclusion has cast out a few million poor. The government subsequently notified 66 OBC groups under a revised arrangement, reducing overall OBC reservation from 17 per cent to seven per cent.

The paucity of fondness can be measured. In its 2026-27 budget, the government reduced the Minority Affairs and Madrasah Education Department's allocation to Rs 2,175.43 crore, against Rs 5,713.61 crore in the interim budget. The allocation for the Aikyashree scholarship scheme, which supports economically disadvantaged